



“Convergence should be of communication, community and institute.”

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Convergence Is Not Congruence

Convergence is not just about technology but is a combination of technology, institute and culture. Take the case of villages, where physical communication is tough vis-à-vis in the cities. But, despite distances being lesser, communication in cities is poorer than in villages. Technology is not necessary for communication.

In terms of communication, technology is the word while the institute becomes the grammar. Communication within communities where modern means are absent is a study. The real problem is communication within the communities.

In a city, the problem is communication within the community. We send e-mails within offices. Communication is not merely about getting information across. There is more to it. Semiotics—the science

of symbols—also forms a big part of communication, and cannot be ignored. Often, more is said through signs than through words... if you take this away, communication is limited.

One point I would like to make here is that in areas where ‘modern’ communication is weak, intra-community communication is strong, and vice-versa. There is, of course, a paradox to this. As mentioned earlier, convergence should be of communication, community and institute. If you consider analogical communication, there are metaphors involved, which may convey part of the meaning. This involves a sender and a recipient. In the case of digital communication, the entropy is much more.

The other paradox is that societies are created and based on the myths, legends and stories they have passed on. This is what creates a culture. This can go forward only through analogue communication. One needs to apply their mind to understand the meaning. What is also done is allows you to understand, own and derive your own meaning.

In the case of digital communication, there is high entropy. Information is trashed much faster. But things like folklore and folk songs are still alive. These have been passed down through analogue communication.

One main challenge we are faced with is the asymmetry of modern technology. There is a division between the ‘haves’ and the ‘have-nots’. There is a need to reduce this, but it is not possible.

By design, any service—including telephony—would like to recover their cost, and wider deployment can help them do this fast. But there

is a cause-and-effect angle to this as well. In such a case, they can survive through innovation. Take, for example, the case of someone in a village who needs to access a doctor or an expert for a crop disease. There are various reasons he cannot; he doesn’t have the money, there is no access to a doctor, or the expert has no knowledge in his area, or there is no research available in the problem he needs addressed. What’s worse is if the wrong problem is focused upon.

A systematic approach could actually help solve this. Let’s re-look the above problem. The common refrain is, “What should I do?” If there were a kiosk, the villager could go and ask the operator for the answers. But what if the operator does not know English and the farmer, too, is illiterate? Does this mean they have to be deprived of the information?